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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

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Place Coverage: !Kung San, Nyae Nyae Region, Namibia

Section Title(S)

The Name-Relationship as a Factor in Social Consolidation

We think that the term *!gu!na* came into the system with the homonymous method and that perhaps it used originally to be applied only to the person for whom ego is named. It is not strictly a kinship term, being composed of translateable words, 'big or old name'. We think it may have been superimposed upon *tun!ga* (which probably comes from the same root as *tūn*). *Tun!ga* may originally have been applied to grandfather, man-speaking as well as woman-speaking, and later *!gu!na* may have become associated with grandfather because so many men are named for their grandfathers. If this is so, an anomalous situation remains unresolved. *Tun!ga* is applied to consanguineous kin and affines and allows joking, woman-speaking. Man-speaking, it is applied only to affines and prohibits joking. If it was originally the term for grandfather, man-speaking, we reason that it should allow joking, and we cannot explain this anomaly.

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Whatever may be the answer to these questions, the !Kung have put to good use the belief that persons who have the same name partake of each other's entities. This belief has given them the name-relationship.

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It is our impression that the practice of applying terms to name-relatives has appealed to the !Kung and that they have developed it to the full. The !Kung apply a kinship term to every !Kung they meet or almost everyone. /Qui was

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the only informant who worked with us on this subject who had ever met a !Kung Bushman for whom he had no kinship term. He had met four who came from a distance and whose names were not among those commonly used in the Nyae Nyae region. Ta//ne was one of the names. Gao, who was present, told /Qui that he had a *tsu* named Ta//ne, and he and /Qui nodded together in agreement that they would find a way for /Qui to give Ta//ne a term should they meet again. We know two men who used the term *!go* for each other because each of them had a brother named Dam. The system seems to have been flexible and expansive in the application of terms to name-relatives.

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The !Kung are small of stature and non-aggressive. They are timid and apprehensive of strangers. Their word for stranger is *ju dole*. *Ju* means person, *dole* means strange or harmful—one word for both concepts, in the !Kung language, as though they were a single concept. The !Kung have no social organization larger than the band of kin who live together but they have utilized the name-relationship to supply the cohesive factor which is supplied in other societies by various social structures. When a !Kung meets a stranger and finds that he has the same name as one of his kin and bestows a kinship term upon him, he is reassured and feels a sense of belonging.

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Gao, the brother of !U, went on an errand for us to Khadum. Khadum is about 115 miles north of Gautscha and about 40 miles north of Cho/ana where we were staying at the time. He had never been to Khadum before, and the !Kung Bushmen who lived ■24 there at once called him *ju dole*. He was in haste to say that he had heard that the father of one of the people at Khadum had the same name as his father and that another had a brother named Gao. 'Oh,' said the Khadum people, in effect, 'so you are Gao's *!gu!na*', and they took him to their fire and gave him a present of edible gum.

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